# USA TRIATHLON

## RACE DIRECTOR RESOURCE GUIDE:

## BIKE: DRAFT-LEGAL RACING

## WHAT IS DRAFT-LEGAL RACING?

Draft-legal racing is a style of triathlon where athletes are allowed to draft (ride behind) other competitors during the bike portion of the event to reduce wind resistance and save energy. This is different from non-draft racing, which characterizes most USA Triathlon sanctioned events, where athletes must maintain a required distance from the athlete in front of them, unless they are overtaking.

**DID YOU KNOW?**

Riders can save as much as 40% of their energy by riding in the slipstream of the rider in front of them.

Draft-legal racing is typically faster, and at times more competitive than non-drafting races, as athletes can use their drafting technique to conserve energy and make strategic moves during the race. However, they also require a high level of skill and strategy, as athletes must be able to anticipate and react to changes in the pack and make decisions about when to draft and when to break away.

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## WHY HOST DRAFT-LEGAL EVENTS:

Draft-legal racing is popular on the world stage as Olympic-level triathlon is hosted in this format. By organizing more draft-legal triathlons here in the U.S., it will open doors to promote the sport of triathlon to a wider audience and encourage more athletes to get involved. In turn, increases in participation lead to more support and resources for the development of triathlon programs and athletes.

### DRAFT-LEGAL EVENTS

#### DEVELOPMENT:

Hosting draft-legal races helps to create a “funnel” for the development of high performance athletes for Team USA. By introducing youth athletes to draft-legal triathlon at an early age, it helps create a development pathway to support and grow the sport, at the grassroots level and at the highest levels of competition.

#### EXPERIENCE:

Draft-legal triathlon levels the playing field for athletes. In non-drafting events, stronger swimmers or bikers may have an advantage over the other disciplines. However, in draft-legal triathlon, athletes can use drafting to conserve energy which allows for closer and more competitive races.

#### OPERATIONS:

Draft-legal courses tend to be more compact, requiring a smaller footprint which allows races to be set up in parks, pools, parking lots or on trails. This compact format also helps to build excitement which creates an ideal setup for spectator and media engagement.

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**HOW TO PRODUCE A DRAFT-LEGAL EVENT:**

Below are a few considerations to take into account as you set out to create a draft-legal event. For more information on the differences between draft-legal and non-drafting race rules, download the Official USAT Multisport Competition Rules at this link:

- ☐ **Closed Bike Course**: The entirety of the bike course must be completely closed to vehicular traffic for the duration of the event. The bike and run routes need to be separate. If there are portions of the route where the bike and run share the same roadway, these lanes need to be clearly delineated with physical equipment (delineators, cones, barricades, etc.)

- ☐ **Separation of Race Groups:** Cyclists are not permitted to draft off athletes of a different gender. As a result, the swim starts are separated by gender to prevent the groups from being on the course at the same time. While genders are kept separate, draft-legal events tend to combine age groups to start together, as opposed to non-drafting events where each age group typically has its own designated wave start.

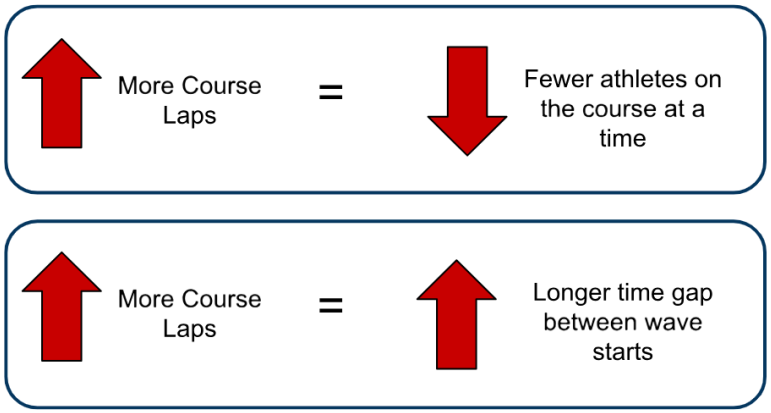
| NON-DRAFTING EVENTS | DRAFT-LEGAL EVENTS |
|---|---|
| ✓ Waves are divided by gender | ✓ Waves are divided by gender |
| ✓ Waves are divided by age | ✗ Waves are not divided by individual age group. All age groups generally start together |
| ✓ Swim starts happen in rapid succession. All waves can be on the course concurrently | ✗ Breaks exist between swim starts to allow time for the course to clear. Waves cannot be on the course concurrently |

Races are set up to occur consecutively with a time gap between starts that allows the bike course to completely clear of any competitors from a previous race gender group before the next wave of athletes begins the race. This model where races are happening one after another elongates the timeline needed for road closures.

| EXAMPLE SCHEDULE OF EVENTS | |
|---|---|
| **RACE GROUP** | **START TIME*** |
| YOUTH GIRLS (ages 12-15) | 8:00 AM |
| YOUTH BOYS (ages 12-15) | 9:00 AM |
| AGE GROUP WOMEN | 2:00 PM |
| AGE GROUP MEN | 3:00 PM |

**The time designated between race starts must reflect the time needed for the preceding group to finish the course. When the horn sounds for each race start, the bike course should be clear of any participants.*

- ☐ **Course Distance:** Since it can be costly to close stretches of roadway for a prolonged period of time, most draft-legal events are sprint or super-sprint distances. Many courses also involve multiple laps. As a general principle, longer length and fewer laps is preferable, as this reduces the risk of potential issues with results on event day.




- ☐ **Course Width:** Wider courses will allow a greater number of athletes to compete safely. Out and back courses are discouraged, but if sections of two-way cyclist traffic are necessary, they must be clearly demarcated with delineation equipment. If there are narrow sections of the course, consider designating these areas as “no passing” zones. Mark with ample warning signage and communicate instructions in the athlete guide and on-site briefings.

- ☐ **Lap Counting:** For multi-loop courses, race management should have a plan in place for keeping track of the number of laps completed. Elite draft-legal races are typically between 3-8 laps on the bike, featuring large packs of athletes. For these events, athletes who have been lapped during the bike segment will be withdrawn from the competition by officials, so as not to interfere with the leaders of the event. As a general rule of thumb, most age group draft-level events do not enforce lap counting.

| ***Pro Tip:*** |
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| *From a safety perspective, it is recommended that age group draft-legal bike courses do not have more than three loops.* |

- ☐ **Separation of Draft-Legal and Non-Drafting Races:** Continuing to offer a non-drafting race as part of your event weekend helps to create an inclusive atmosphere where those who may not be comfortable with draft-legal racing are still able to participate. However, it is important to note that non-drafting races must be completely separate from the draft-legal race(s). The timelines of these races cannot overlap.

**SAFETY CONSIDERATIONS:**

When it comes to logistics and safety planning for draft-legal events, the needs closely mirror non-drafting events. Check out the Bike: Logistics Planning Resource Guide for more information on general bike course planning and management. Below are a few additional considerations specific to draft-legal racing:

| DRAFT-LEGAL SAFETY CONSIDERATIONS | |
|---|---|
| **CATEGORY** | **CONSIDERATION** |
| OVERTAKING | • Individuals can overtake packs. Packs can also overtake other packs.As a general rule of thumb, athletes should be started from fastest to slowest. The more instances of packs overtaking slower riders the greater the risk. To the extent possible, race planning should seek to reduce the amount of overtaking required by athletes. |
| SPEED | • Athletes are likely to be traveling at higher rates of speed than non-drafting events. This may make it more challenging for athletes to maneuver through sections of the course that involve steep descents, sharp turns, or other technical features. Additional risk mitigation efforts may be necessary. |
| VISIBILITY | • Athletes are likely to be traveling in large packs, which can reduce their ability to see upcoming hazards and hear instructions from course marshals and staff. |
| SPECTATORS | • Highly trafficked spectator areas should have an organized system for crossing that involves barricades and marshal support. For more information on executing standard/busy course crossings, consult the Course Design section of the Bike: Logistics Planning Resource Guide |
| VEHICLES | • The presence of vehicles on the course should be limited to essential personnel only. In instances where vehicle movement is necessary, it is best practice that vehicles only travel in the same direction as competitors. |
| MEDICAL | • The potential for on-course incidents to involve multiple athletes may be higher in a draft-legal event. Additional medical planning and resource needs should take this into account and there should be adequate planning to backfill asset resources that leave the race site to transport athletes to medical facilities.<br>• Movement for emergency response vehicles may be difficult with large packs on the course, however there are likely to be bigger gaps between competitors than with non-drafting races.<br>• Pre-race planning should consider where emergency response vehicles will park while responding to an incident where they are not blocking the course and approaching athletes are able to be warned that a vehicle is up ahead. |

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